

Pollen

Seeded, it shook. Belled, it shook. Smiling, he shook his head. The seeded gourd initiated, and the belled staff assented. And the old shrink wondered how it was that they always knew before him.

Through all this rattling, the newest biographer sat firm in her rocking chair.

They were on his ranch porch. He retired with stripes, she in search of her own. But more than that, she wanted to make good on the symmetry of her opportunity to work with him. He was not a local, regional, or national hero, no. He saved humanity from the droughts. Solved them, digested them before anyone else could. The renowned and experienced biographers had been here already, she knew. It was the greenhorn's chance now. The psychiatrist refused email and text. Preferred face-to-face meetings, where nothing could be hidden of a person. Phone calls were specifically and only used to coordinate or adjust plans. More, less? Neither. All this may sound strict, but he knew it to be necessary. There is a certain obligation when any experience must be conveyed to another person. Let alone that this story will travel through the chosen person's own lens and then through their pen, to the rest of the world. What an aperture he was in search of. Good god, he thought.

And yet there they sat. All these thoughts swirling and intermingling and afloat in the neurochemistry. The surface tension was, accordingly, too great. Great-big sky above, ever-so-slight ranch below: the ranch may have been dry, but the sky? Milky blue.

His home verged on ocean-less bungalow in the Texas desert. Water-strider? No no, that can't be right, more like a sky-strider, he decided. The ranch was hardly what she had imagined. In much politer packaging, she made comment on this. Hoping to break the tension herself. It didn't. Maybe not polite enough, she thought.

The doctor's cane rattled as the breeze rustled. For a moment she wasn't sure if the two, the cane and the breeze, were linked somehow. As if one were causing the other. Feeling a rattle of her own and thinking maybe he'll appreciate some boldness, she asked what everyone was thinking:

—How did you solve the droughts, doctor?

—To answer that question. Would be to write the book.

—You mean your whole life...

—The events of my, built me into the person who could protect...

—Us.

—Yes. Anyone in my position could have done it.

—I don't know that everyone would, though.

—I avoid speculating like that. For my own sake.

The doctor punctuated this last with a lifting of his rattle cane and a releasing of it. The biographer, who was trying to quit smoking, snapped off a nib of her candy cigarette. The shrink loosed a light, dry laugh of appreciation. Her mind wandered back to just a few moments before; the handshake between rattle and breeze struck her a second time. With a small tilt of the head and a smile, she returned her attention to him:

—Well why don't we start toward the beginning, what is an early memory or event that primed you for solving the droughts?

—Ah.

—...

The psychiatrist seemed to rattle his cane without moving it.

—What's wrong, doctor?

—I wouldn't say there is anything wrong in how you've phrased your question, but I do think it should be said that it is an arboreal one.

—How do you mean?

—It seeks to build a foundation first, seeks to start from the bottom and move upwards toward the present layer or canopy of the moment. What I would like for you to internalize for yourself, not for the biography I want you to write of me, is that life doesn't always have to be that way.

—I see. What are some examples? I'm curious, sir.

—Ah well, that gets into writing the whole book again. Part of the solution to the droughts was realizing this rhizomatic structure within the world. Look at me, for example. I solved them within my hospital system and the solution spread from that site in a quite fragmented manner.

—Can we define rhizome, please?

Catherine brought out her voice recorder. Dr. Otsuka asked for a candy cigarette. After immediately snapping off a nib of his own as if preparing a fountain pen, he began again.

—Rhizome in this case refers to a group of elements. In this case all life on the planet. None of these elements are linked, at least not by proximity, not even necessarily by relationship or knowledge of each other.

—Is it off-base to use the language of quantum mechanics here, doctor?

—You might develop that understanding from someone more fluent in it, but yes it seems a useful framework, at least from where I sit. Yet it's important to realize that quantum entanglement and the other terms do not capture the droughts. Not in their entirety.

—I see, but please continue. Let's get back to the rhizome.

—Yes. I'm fond of the neighborhood metaphor. Which is to say, we all belong to a vast neighborhood, Jung called it the collective unconscious. I call it a neighborhood. Call me Mr. Rogers if you like.

—I will not but thank you for the offer.

—Yes well the offer's shelf life is about a week. I like the idea of him having tattoo sleeves under those cardigans. But anyway,

—Is that why you're wearing a puffer jacket, doctor?

—Don't slander me on your recording!

The doctor leaned toward the recorder, enunciating each word,

—Please, Catherine the Editor. Don't let them know I'm running cold these days! Resist Catherine the Biographer!

For the first time in quite a while, Catherine loosed her own light laugh. Although her tally of "light laughs" wasn't all that well-kept, it still struck her.

—B'yes, to answer your question, the neighborhood metaphor describes us as belonging to a collective. Much of this has been explained by Jung already. The archetypes and so on, but the twist here is those droughts. Usually these connections and communications only occur subconsciously or during sleep. During the droughts, though? ... Pandora's Box? *Open season*.

Catherine and Dr. Otsuka were both rocking in their chairs by this point. Eagerly snapping away at candy cigarettes (Catherine brought a box, not a pack or carton) and shooting the breeze together. At some point, Dr. Otsuka broke the flow of conversation about strategy in All 5s Dominos and said:

—Catherine.

—Eh uh yes? I didn't mean to say that snake eyes is a bad domino! I just meant that it's loaded with bad luck for me...

—Catherine, we've discussed dominos and pizza. Baseball, beer, and music. Literature. Do you know what this represents, what this means.

She saw his point immediately. She'd taken classes and done workshops. Understood, abstractly, how biographies written and, more broadly, how journalism was conducted. But until Dr. Otsuka posed his question, she hadn't felt the purpose of the theory.

—Doctor. A lot just clicked into place for me. I'm new to this and well I mean I'm just out of college recently...

—Catherine, I need for you to show that you understand.

—A good biography requires a rhizome of a person. Not an arboreal model. The bits and pieces that inform the whole of itself.

Yes.